

UNSCRIPTED SMALL BUSINESS · A NOTE FROM ANA

Water Damage, Mold & Money

How I built a home-rescue business by accident.

I'm Ana Schwab. I own Total Home Rescue — water-damage restoration, mold remediation, and build-back across Washington DC, Virginia, and Maryland. I fight the insurance claim so the homeowner never pays out of pocket. Here's the version of our conversation I'd hand a friend.

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unscriptedsmallbusiness.com/how-i-built-a-home-rescue-business-by-accident

Me: totalhomerescue.pro · The show: unscriptedsmallbusiness.com



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Six ideas from the episode

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WHY I WROTE THIS

I started Total Home Rescue from basically zero dollars after simply hearing that water damage can be covered by insurance. These are the six things I most want people to take away — whether you run a home-services business, deal with insurers, or are just deciding whether SEO is worth it.

CHAPTER 01

Insurance is the real job — you pay \$0

My real work isn't drying out a basement — it's the claim. Because everyone has to carry insurance, I put myself between the homeowner and the insurer and keep the customer "aside" from the money entirely. Whether a job runs \$200,000 or a million dollars, your job is to feel confident and safe, not to pay out of pocket.

That matters because insurers don't really like paying out. They cut estimates, trim invoices, and delay. My counter is airtight documentation and a willingness to fight. On my worst-ever project — a roughly 4,000 sq ft, three-story house with mold everywhere — the insurer first refused to cover anything, and I still got them to pay the roughly \$200,000 bill.

CHAPTER 02

Bleach is not remediation

Most homeowners think mold isn't serious and that a little bleach will handle it. It's not true. Depending on severity, real remediation ranges from spraying, wiping, and coating with antimicrobial products all the way to demolishing everything down to the studs.

My two biggest warning signs: any history of a leak — even 10 years ago, even five years ago a tiny leak can become a huge problem — and a musty smell in the corner of a room or under the sink. Most customers want the quick wipe-and-move-on; but the situation, not your preference, decides what the job actually is.

CHAPTER 03

A system beats relying on yourself

I'm a "legal freak," and it shows in how I run the company. I won't start work until agreements are signed protecting both parties, I send a follow-up email after every phone agreement, and I ask for a signed certificate of satisfaction at the end — uncommon for US contractors, and exactly why I have no legal disputes. Being "all wrapped up in paperwork" is the moat.

"A system is the most important thing that you can have in your business. You should not rely on yourself only. You should rely on your documents, on instructions that you have for your employees and on numbers."

— Anastasiya Schwab

But paperwork is just one expression of a bigger belief: the owner should not be the single point of failure. Documents, written instructions for my employees, and hard numbers are what keep the business running when I'm not in the room.

CHAPTER 04

The business I built by accident

I don't write business plans. When friends tell me I can't do something, I bet them I can — and my impulse ventures keep working out. Before Total Home Rescue I ran a dentistry clinic and a clothing brand; each one started the same accidental way.

“When I tried to think everything through to create a business plan, never works out for me. But when I do a business by accident, it works very well.”

— Anastasiia Schwab

I launched this company from basically zero dollars after hearing that water damage can be covered by insurance, then reasoned it through: in the US, pipes burst constantly, everyone carries insurance, so demand never really stops. The plan came after the leap, not before it.

CHAPTER 05

Why SEO customers convert better than paid

I started doing my own website SEO about two months before we spoke, with zero dollars invested — and it already brings in at least two leads a week. What matters more is the quality: a homeowner converts about 20% of paid-ad callers but 30% of SEO callers, because people who read through the website arrive more prepared, already trusting me and seeing my authority.

“I started to do our website SEO probably two months ago. And I can tell you that I receive at least two leads per week.”

— Anastasiya Schwab

My cautionary tale is public adjusters. Many relied purely on referrals and networking, ignored their websites and Google Business profiles, and after a law change lost roughly 45–50% of their revenue — because they’d never invested in the channel that keeps working when the phone stops ringing.

CHAPTER 06

The numbers — a team of 10, scaling to 45

Total Home Rescue runs on a team of 10 employees plus a bench of on-call contractors I can call when needed. At the time of recording I had seven projects going, against a normal cadence of about 15 a month — and a goal of 45 a month.

I want to grow deeper, not wider. I deliberately stay inside DC, Virginia, and Maryland so I can be physically on-site, and my next growth lever is business development — deepening insurance relationships toward preferred-vendor and TPA-network status, currently blocked only because my company was registered too recently to qualify.

IDEAS WORTH STEALING

Seven things I'd tell any owner

- 01** Keep the customer out of the money fight — stand between them and the insurer.
- 02** Get everything in writing: signed agreement, certificate of satisfaction, email confirmation.
- 03** Bleach isn't remediation — match the fix to the severity, not the customer's wish.
- 04** Deliberate plans can stall; sometimes you learn the business by building it.
- 05** Run on systems — documents, employee instructions, and numbers — not on yourself.
- 06** SEO customers arrive pre-sold and convert higher (≈30% vs ≈20% paid).
- 07** Treat SEO as a compounding investment, not a switch you turn off.

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